CHAPTER 6 · DEEP DIVE · HOUSE & DIVIDED

Secession Winter

In the weeks after Lincoln's election, the Union began to come apart — state by state. 1860–1861.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

In the weeks after Lincoln's election, the Union began to come apart — state by state. 1860–1861.

When a state decides to leave the country, how does it explain why — and do its own words match the reasons we're sometimes told?

South Carolina Goes First

DECEMBER 20, 1860

Lincoln would not be inaugurated until March. The South did not wait. Just six weeks after the election, a special convention in South Carolina voted unanimously to leave the United States.

Within hours, printers flooded the streets of Charleston with a broadside announcing the news in letters four inches tall.

"The Union Is Dissolved!" — broadside, Charleston Mercury, December 20, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

"The Union Is Dissolved!"

THE ANNOUNCEMENT

Charleston, December 20, 1860. The first state was gone — and the broadside made sure everyone knew.

"The Union Is Dissolved!" — broadside, Charleston Mercury, December 20, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Deep South Follows

WINTER 1860–61

South Carolina was only the first. Over the next six weeks, six more states of the Deep South held conventions and voted to secede: Mississippi, Florida, Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, and Texas.

In February 1861 — still weeks before Lincoln took office — delegates met in Montgomery, Alabama, formed the Confederate States of America, and chose Jefferson Davis as president. There were now two governments where one had stood.

South Carolina Ordinance of Secession (detail) — broadside, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Ordinance of Secession

THE LEGAL ACT

The formal wording: the union "is hereby dissolved." A government taken apart in a single paragraph.

South Carolina Ordinance of Secession (detail) — broadside, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

Why They Said They Left

THE STATED REASON

Secession conventions didn't just vote — several published a “Declaration of the Causes” explaining their decision to the world. South Carolina's is blunt, and it is worth reading in its own words.

It does not lead with taxes, or states' rights in the abstract. It leads with slavery — naming the North's “hostility to the institution of slavery” as the central grievance. The documents of the moment tell us plainly what the moment was about.

“The Union Is Dissolved!” — broadside, Charleston Mercury, December 20, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOUTH CAROLINA, DECLARATION OF THE CAUSES OF SECESSION · 1860

[The non-slaveholding States] have denounced as sinful the institution of slavery … and have encouraged … thousands of our slaves to leave their homes.

— DECLARATION OF THE IMMEDIATE CAUSES … OF SECESSION

The Last Six Weeks of Peace

WHY IT MATTERS

By the time Lincoln was sworn in, seven states had already gone. He faced a question no president had ever faced: was secession even legal — and if not, was it worth a war to stop it?

The compromises were finished. The votes were counted. All that remained was the question of force — and the answer was waiting at a federal fort in Charleston Harbor called Sumter.

“The Union Is Dissolved!” — broadside, Charleston Mercury, December 20, 1860, public domain (Library of Congress).

Put the Winter in Order

YOUR TURN

You'll sequence the events of Secession Winter and read South Carolina's own explanation — practicing two historian's skills: sequencing and contextualization (judging a moment by the evidence it left).